Alternative to Walking Meditation

MINDFULNESS MEDITATION TEACHER CERTIFICATION PROGRAM

Script for Guided Meditation

For those with difficulty walking

Mindful movement is a powerful way to cultivate present moment awareness. Simple, repetitive actions can develop calm and a greater sense of here and now. If you have challenges doing walking meditation or other forms of mindful movement, you may enjoy this variation.

You can do the following practice seated or even lying down. You can have your eyes closed or eyes open. Feel free to customize this technique so it works best for you.

Your hands are your primary anchor, or point of focus, for this practice. Be as mindful as you can of the movement and all the accompanying sensations. This moving meditation will begin with conscious breathing with the movement. Feel free to explore the movement with your breathing free and unrestricted.

Let your hands rest comfortably on the tops of your thighs. Close your eyes, or let them be open with a relaxed, soft gaze. Relax. Open your awareness to the sounds around you, the sense of smell, taste, and touch.

How intimately can you feel your hands from the inside right now? Feel the backs of the hands. Feel the volume of the palms, fingers, and thumbs. Feel the space between the fingers. You may be able to sense the pulse, tingling, or subtle sensations.

Bring your attention to your right hand, palm against your thigh.

Gently turn the palm facing up.

As you inhale, gently lift your right hand about five or six inches off your thigh. You might inwardly whisper to yourself, “Lifting.”

Turn the palm facing down, and exhaling slowly, lower the palm to your thigh. You might inwardly whisper, “Placing.”

Bring your attention to your left hand, palm against your thigh.

Gently turn the palm facing up.

As you inhale, gently lift your left hand about five or six inches off your thigh. You might inwardly whisper to yourself, “Lifting.”

Turn the palm facing down, and exhaling slowly, lower the palm to your thigh. You might inwardly whisper, “Placing.”

Alternating now, lift and place your hands, consciously breathing with the movement and labeling “lifting” or “placing.” Let the movement be smooth and as natural as possible. Notice how intimately you can time the breath with the movement of the hands. The breath should feel easy, with no strain.

As you continue, you might release control of the breath. Focus on the movement, noting what is happening as it’s happening.

Feel free to experiment. It might be helpful to vary the pace, slowing down or speeding up slightly as you feel the movement of the hands.

Experiment with the practice of labeling. You might concentrate on naming “lifting” and “placing” precisely as the movement is happening, but also feel free to drop the technique of labeling and focus more on the flow of movement.

Just as with breath-based meditation, your attention will wander again and again. When you notice your mind has drifted, acknowledge this moment of wakefulness and guide your attention back to the practice.

Continue for as long as it feels helpful.

Use this practice anytime to gather your attention and cultivate a more embodied sense of presence.